

ANIMAL PEOPLE

News For People Who Care About Animals



A Project of Animal People, Inc., 1992-2013

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PETA SLAUGHTERHOUSE VIDEO STIRS DISPUTE OVER KOSHER STANDARDS

[December 1, 2004](#) | [Archivist](#) | [Leave a comment](#)

From ANIMAL PEOPLE, December 2004:

POSTVILLE, Iowa—AgriProcessors Inc., the only U.S. slaughterhouse authorized to export meat to Israel, agreed on December 7, 2004 to cease ripping the trachea and esophagus out of cattle immediately after their throats are cut, and to use a captive bolt gun to dispatch cattle who try to regain their footing after the throat-cutting. Meat from those cattle will no longer be sold as kosher. AgriProcessors, marketing under the name “Aaron’s Best,” denied that pulling the windpipes out of living cattle was part of their killing routine, but workers were shown doing it

in a 30-minute undercover video released by PETA on November 30. A PETA staff member worked at AgriProcessors for seven weeks during the summer of 2004. Kosher experts disagreed as to whether the throat-tearing met kosher requirements. Orthodox Union chief rabbis Menachem Genack and Yisroel Blsky said it was “gruesome” but kosher; Orthodox Union executive vice president Tzvi Hersh Weinreb called it “especially inhumane” and “generally unacceptable”; Shiumon Cohen of the British organization Shchita U.K. said it was not kosher; and Ezra Raful, chief of international slaughter supervision for the chief rabbinate of Israel, told the Jerusalem Post that technically the slaughter was kosher, but definitely did not follow recommended practice.

Colorado State University professor Temple Grandin, who designed the double-rail restraint system now used in most U.S. kosher slaughterhouses, called the throat-ripping “An atrocious abomination, nothing like I’ve seen in 30 kosher plants I’ve visited in the U.S., England, France, Ireland, and Canada.” Originally a conventional slaughterhouse, the AgriProcessors plant was purchased in 1987 by a Hasidic group from Brooklyn, New

York, and converted to perform kosher slaughter to the glatt (highest) standard. The transition was topic of a book, Postville: A Clash of Cultures in Heartland America, by Stephen G. Bloom (2000).

Campaigns

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- November
2013
- October
2013
- September
2013
- July 2013
- May 2013
- April
2013
- March
2013
- January
2013
- November
2012
- October
2012
- September
2012
- July 2012
- June
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- May 2012
- April
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- Activists
&
Organization
s
- Africa
- Animal
Sacrifice
- Animals
in
Entertainment
- Animals
in Research
- Art
- Asia
- Australia
& Pacific
Islands
- Awards
- Bloodsports
- Campaigns
- Companion
Animals
- Culture
- Diets
- Disaster
Relief
- Editorials
- Environment
- Europe
- Farm
Animals
- Fashion
- Fur &
Skin

- Human Rights
- Hunting & Fishing
- Latin America
- Law
- Letters
- Lifestyles
- Marine Animals
- Medicine
- Middle East
- North America
- Nuisance Animals
- Obituaries
- Politics
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- Science
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- Travel
- Uncategorized
- Wild Animals
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